ClientFlow

What it costs to put ClientFlow live.

Hosting, domain, email, payments, and everything else the backend needs to run, priced line by line, with three budget options and a timeline of when each cost actually starts.

PREPARED
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STATUS
Planning only. Nothing purchased yet.

The short answer

Running ClientFlow costs roughly **$32 – $53 a month** on the recommended setup, or as little as **$6 – $11 a month** if you use free tiers wherever possible. On top of that you pay once a year for a domain, and a percentage of every customer payment goes to the payment processor.

LEAN	RECOMMENDED	MANAGED
$6 – $11 per month. Cheapest workable setup, you manage the server	**$32 – $53** per month. Same server approach, paid email and inbox	**$71 – $169** per month. No server to look after, costs more

	Lean	Recommended	Managed
Per month	$6 – $11	$32 – $53	$71 – $169
One-time / yearly extras	Domain + legal docs	Domain + legal docs	Domain + legal docs
Year one, all in*	$82 – $294	$394 – $798	$862 – $2,190
Server work for you	Yes — Linux, backups, updates	Yes — same	Very little
Customers to cover it**	1 Starter	1 Growth	1–3 Growth

* Year one includes 12 months of running costs, one year of domain, and privacy policy / terms, with the domain priced as sendclientflow.com. It excludes payment processing fees and the cost of building the backend.
** Starter is $29/month, Growth $79/month, from the pricing page.

The biggest cost is not hosting

If you are hiring someone to build the backend, that bill will be larger than several years of hosting combined. Section 5 covers it. If you build it yourself with an AI coding assistant, the cost is mostly your time plus a subscription.

Domain chosen: sendclientflow.com

clientflow.com, clientflow.io and most variants are registered by others, so the product runs on sendclientflow.com while the company and brand stay ClientFlow. It was available when checked in October 2026 and costs about $10 a year at Cloudflare or Namecheap. Register it before anything else, because the Google verification, the system emails and the code all point at it.

One-time and yearly costs

These are paid once before launch, or once a year. Most of the "setup" work for this product, such as Google and Microsoft app registration, is free; it costs time, not money.

Item	Cost	Notes
Domain: sendclientflow.com	$10 – $12 / year	Cloudflare sells at cost with no renewal markup. Turn on auto-renew so it never lapses.
Privacy policy + terms of service	$0 – $150	Required by Google before it will approve your app. A generator works to start; the Google policy must specifically describe how you use Gmail data.
Lawyer review of the above (optional)	$300 – $1,500	Worth it once paying customers arrive, given the product sends email on their behalf.
Google OAuth app verification	Free	For the gmail.send scope recommended in BACKEND_SPEC.md. Takes weeks, so start early.
Microsoft app / publisher verification	Free	Needs a free Microsoft Partner Network account and your verified domain.
SSL certificates	Free	Let's Encrypt, renewed automatically.
Stripe or Paystack account	Free to open	They charge per payment instead (section 4).
Business registration	Varies by country	Payment processors need a registered business. See the note in section 4 about Stripe.

Monthly running costs, line by line

All three setups run the same backend from BACKEND_SPEC.md: a Node API, a background worker that sends the email, MongoDB, and Redis. They differ in who looks after the machines.

Lean

One small server holds everything. Free tiers for the rest. Good for building, testing, and the first handful of customers.

Item	Per month
Server (2 vCPU / 4GB, Hetzner-class)	$5 – $9
Server backups	$1 – $2
Frontend hosting (Cloudflare Pages)	Free
System email (Resend / Brevo free tier)	Free
Company inbox (Cloudflare forwarding)	Free
Error tracking + uptime (free tiers)	Free
SSL + DNS (Let's Encrypt, Cloudflare)	Free
Total per month	$6 – $11

Recommended

Still one server, but with room to grow, a reliable paid service for password-reset and billing emails, and a proper support@ inbox. This is what the backend spec was written for.

Item	Per month
Server (4 vCPU / 8GB Hetzner, or 2 vCPU / 4GB DigitalOcean)	$8 – $24
Server backups + off-server copy	$2 – $5
Frontend hosting (Cloudflare Pages or same server)	Free
System email (Postmark Basic)	$15
Company inbox (Google Workspace, 1 user)	$7 – $9
Error tracking + uptime (free tiers)	Free
SSL + DNS (Let's Encrypt, Cloudflare)	Free
Total per month	$32 – $53

Managed

Each piece is rented from a company that runs it for you. No Linux, no manual backups. You pay for that convenience.

Item	Per month
API + worker (Render / Railway)	$14 – $50
MongoDB Atlas (managed database)	$10 – $60
Redis (managed, small plan)	$5 – $15
Frontend hosting (Vercel Pro)	$20
System email (Postmark Basic)	$15
Company inbox (Google Workspace, 1 user)	$7 – $9
Error tracking + uptime (free tiers)	Free
Total per month	$71 – $169

About the frontend hosting

The repo has a vercel.json, so it was set up for Vercel. Vercel's free Hobby plan is for non-commercial use only; a paid SaaS needs Vercel Pro at $20/month per member. Cloudflare Pages is free for commercial sites, and the backend spec also shows how to serve the built frontend from the same server for $0. Either saves the $20.

Costs that grow with customers

These are zero until you have customers, then scale with them. None of them should worry you: each one is a sign the business is working.

Item	How it is charged	Example
Stripe card payments	2.9% + $0.30 per successful charge (US rate). +1.5% for international cards, +1% if currency conversion applies.	A $79 Growth payment costs $2.59; you keep $76.41.
Paystack card payments	Local Nigerian cards: 1.5% + NGN 100 (fee capped at NGN 2,000). International cards: 3.9% + NGN 100.	Cheaper for local customers. Confirm current rates at paystack.com.
System email over the free/Basic quota	Postmark Basic includes 10,000 emails; about $1.80 per extra 1,000.	Only password resets, receipts and alerts go through this. Customer campaigns send from their own mailboxes, so they cost you nothing here.
Bigger server	Upgrade when the server is busy.	Roughly 100+ active customers: plan for $25 – $100 / month.
Google CASA security assessment	Yearly, by a Google-approved assessor.	Only if you later switch to reading Gmail via the API (gmail.readonly). Vendor estimates start around $540 – $1,000 / year for self-serve Tier 2 and go much higher. The spec's IMAP approach avoids this at launch.
More team inboxes	Google Workspace, about $7 – $9 per person per month.	When someone joins to help with support.

Stripe and where your business is registered

Stripe only accepts businesses registered in the countries it supports, and Nigeria is not one of them. If that applies to you, the options are Paystack (owned by Stripe, already planned for in the spec), or forming a US company through Stripe Atlas, which costs $500 once plus yearly US registered-agent, state and tax-filing costs. Paystack alone is the cheaper way to start.

Building the backend

Hosting is cheap. Building the thing you host is where the real money or time goes. BACKEND_SPEC.md describes a serious system: separate accounts per customer, Gmail and Outlook sign-in, a sending engine with daily limits and warm-up, reply detection, billing webhooks, and an admin panel. The business plan breaks it into ten stages.

Route	Rough cost	What to know
Build it yourself with an AI coding assistant	$20 – $200 / month while building	The spec was written to be pasted into one. You still need to understand what it writes, especially the security checklist in section 12 of the spec.
Freelance backend developer	Typically $2,000 – $10,000+	Depends heavily on country and experience. Get fixed-price quotes per stage, not one lump sum, and own the code and server accounts yourself.
Agency	$10,000 – $40,000+	Faster and more managed, rarely necessary at this stage.
Ongoing maintenance	A few hours a month	Security updates, fixing broken mailboxes, answering deliverability questions. If someone else does this, budget for a monthly retainer.

These ranges are deliberately wide

Developer rates vary more than any other number in this document. Treat the freelance and agency figures as a sense of scale, and replace them with real quotes once you share the spec with two or three developers.

When each cost starts

You do not need to pay for anything until the backend is being built. Here is the order, so money goes out only when it has to.

Stage	What to pay for	Running total / month
Now (planning)	Register sendclientflow.com (about $10 for the year) so nobody else takes it. Nothing else yet.	$0 + $10 once
Backend build starts	Develop locally, or on free MongoDB Atlas and Redis tiers. Create the Google Cloud and Microsoft app registrations (free). AI coding tool or developer, if used.	$0 – $1 + build cost
Working Gmail sign-in	Put the landing page, privacy policy and terms live on the domain (Cloudflare Pages, free). Submit Google verification now; it takes weeks.	$0 – $1
Staging / testing	Rent the server and turn on backups. Run with DRY_RUN=true.	$6 – $11
Launch	Postmark, Google Workspace for support@, payment account live.	$32 – $53
~100 customers	Bigger server, possibly a second one for the worker.	$60 – $150

Before you spend anything

- Register sendclientflow.com, with auto-renew on.
- Check which payment processor can accept your business, based on where it is registered.
- Decide who builds the backend, and get quotes if it is not you.
- Choose Lean or Recommended hosting. You can start Lean and move up without rebuilding anything.
- Re-check the prices in this document on each provider's page. Several (Hetzner, Postmark, .io domains) changed in 2026.

Where these figures come from

Published pricing and comparison pages checked in October 2026: Hetzner Cloud (prices changed in April and June 2026 for new orders), DigitalOcean, Postmark, Resend, Cloudflare Registrar and Pages, Vercel, MongoDB Atlas, Render, Google Workspace, Stripe, Paystack, and Google's OAuth verification documentation. Exchange rates, taxes such as VAT, and promotional discounts are not included. These are estimates for planning, not quotes.